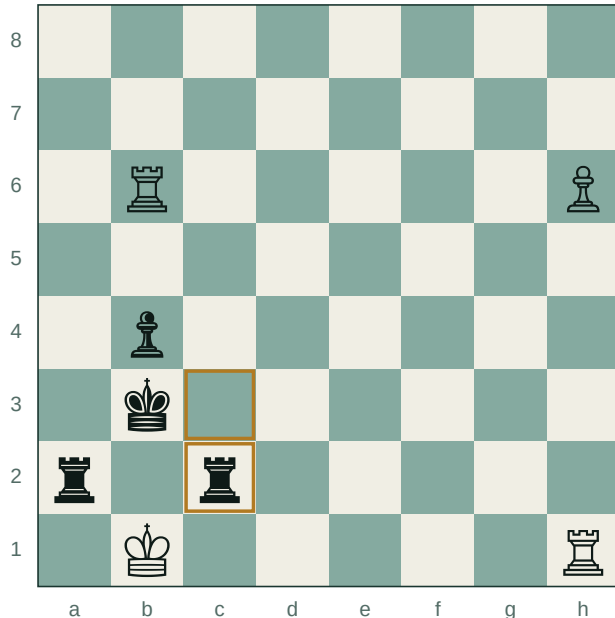


Rook-ending tactics: White, move 54

Rook-ending tactics

White to move



Previous move: 53...Rcc2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

54. Rh3+ Kc4 55. Rc6+ Kd5 56. Rxc2

54.Rh3+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **54...Kc4**.

55.Rc6+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **55...Kd5**.

56.Rxc2 The rook captures the rook on c2.

At the end, nominal material is White 11 / Black 6 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from +0 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A routine rook placement can miss a skewer or promotion with check. Let concrete tactics override a guideline when they conflict.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Rook endings combine pawn races with checks, cutoffs, and promotion tactics. Activity is vital, but the exact move order often decides whether a pawn can advance safely.

HOW TO LOOK

Check the kings' exposure, the rooks' checking distance, and the passed pawns. Calculate forcing checks before applying a general rook-ending rule.

The defending king is on b3. Absolute pin: pawn on b4.